best. India's post-Independence policy towards its immediate South Asian neighbours exemplifies this policy best. Delhi, whether under the British or after, has always believed that India's Central government is best suited to make security decisions. Just like British officers during the Raj, the advocates of an imperial foreign policy for independent India insist that its South Asian neighbours should agree and accept that India's security needs are theirs as well. Even the idealist Nehru reflected a Curzonian mindset[20] when it came to the subcontinent and India's adjacent states. His daughter, Indira Gandhi, proclaimed what came to be called the Indira doctrine, similar to the American Monroe doctrine, reserving primacy for India in making security decisions for its neighbourhood.

'Messianic Idealism,' reflecting the mantra of global peace, justice and prosperity has served as the strong moral component of India's foreign policy, inspired by the moral legacy of ancient Indian thought reiterated during the national struggle under Mahatma Gandhi. Proponents of this perspective believe that India is an example for the world and that India has the duty to proclaim that example for other nations. This element of Indian exceptionalism often forms part of India's view of itself and of the world. Every Indian leader, whether Gandhi or Vivekananda, whether Nehru or Modi, has demanded that the rest of the world accord India stature commensurate with its civilizational contribution.

It is a function of India's messianic idealism that Indians, whether the lay public or their leaders, have always believed in India's heritage as a great civilization and have anticipated the future as a great power. It is almost as if all India has to do is to wait for the world to accept its greatness. India has often claimed the moral high ground in international relations and believed that it has the right to preach to other nations about what policies to adopt. During the cold war, India used multilateral venues, like the annual United Nations gatherings and the NAM and G-77 groupings for philosophical elocutions on right and wrong that others saw as sermonizing.